

Marketing, Advertising, and Social Media

by Sophia



WHAT'S COVERED

In this lesson, you will learn about some of the ethical questions specific to advertising and marketing. Specifically, you will learn about:

1. Pervasive Persuasion

The advertising industry creates messages in a variety of media—print, online, television, radio, and signage—urging the purchase of products or services. The industry may start with a real need that we all share, or fabricate it, manufacture it, or transform it into something we never knew we needed but now cannot imagine living without. For example, you do not need a Birkin bag from Hermès to carry things every day, but the demand for them is off the charts, and they start at over \$10,000. There may be no ethical issue at all with an amazing handbag, well-earned with work and effort, but there certainly are ethical issues associated with the intentional manufacturing of desires and wants to drive consumer behaviors. The advertising industry has manipulation down to a literal science. They sell us not just products, but concepts.

As consumers, we need and want to be informed, and this element of advertising is useful to society. If we expect the buyer to beware, as consumers, we also want to be well informed with valid, useful information. Yet much of advertising is intended to lead to the purchase of goods and services we do not need. Advertising also exists to coerce, manipulate, or encourage us to feel a certain way, often about ourselves, so that we'll buy something. Advertising distorts our understanding of normal body shapes and sizes, normal tastes, colors, and smells, and tells us if we only buy a product, we'll be taller, thinner, and more attractive. Some ads may make claims containing only the thinnest slice of truth, or exaggerate and distort what the goods and services can actually deliver. All advertisements are persuasive in some way and aim to sell. Most often, advertisers rely on suggestive imagery and association rather than making outright claims. Buy this product and you'll be more popular, more attractive, more respected, or have more fun. All these tactics raise serious ethical concerns.

By its very purpose, advertising aims to persuade consumers to buy goods and services, many of which are nonessential. Although consumers have long been encouraged to heed the warning *caveat emptor* (let the buyer beware), it is a valid question whether advertisers have any ethical obligation to rein in the oft-exaggerated claims of their marketing pitches, or the power of suggestion which much of advertising relies on to avoid telling outright lies. Most consumers emphatically would agree that they do. To accept otherwise is to invite fraud, damage, and possibly harm.

Economist John Kenneth Galbraith addressed this issue in *The Affluent Society*, first published in 1958. In what he depicted as “the dependence effect,” Galbraith described the power of corporations to harness wide-

ranging advertising strategies, marketing efforts, and sales pitches to influence consumer purchasing decisions. He asked whether it is possible for a sophisticated advertising campaign to create a demand for a product whose benefits are frivolous at best. If so, is there anything inherently wrong with that? Or are informed consumers themselves responsible for resisting tempting—though misleading—advertising claims and exercising their own best judgment about whether to buy a product that might be successful, not because it deserves to be but simply because of the marketing hype behind it? These questions remain fundamental to the manager’s task of creating ethical advertising campaigns in which truthful content is prioritized over inducing wasteful consumption.

Psychological appeals form the basis of the most successful ads. Going beyond the standard ad pitch about the product’s advantages, **psychological appeals** try to reach our self-esteem and persuade us that we will feel better about ourselves if we use certain products. They appeal to our emotions, not our reason. They play to our feelings, not our rational thoughts. They can short-circuit our own ability to think through a purchase decision as the desire and the feelings of want overwhelm us. Like shortcuts, they can go directly to the pleasure centers of our brains and make them light up like Christmas. They can also play on our fears, doubts, and confusion, and contribute to unreasonable expectations for ourselves. Persuasive strategies used by advertisements aim to sell, and may not show us the complete picture, or even provide much information at all.



REFLECT

Many people think they are immune to the effects of advertising. The misconception is that advertising will have an immediate effect, but advertising rarely works that way. As advertising executive Nigel Hollis writes, advertisers are more interested in creating brand awareness and impressions for a long-term payoff (2011). If you see an ad for a jewelry store with a memorable jingle, for example, you are not likely to immediately buy an expensive gift for someone, but the next time you do purchase something, you may be drawn to the familiar store with the catchy tune. Your awareness of the brand and good impressions of the company make you more trusting than you would be of an unfamiliar brand.



TERM TO KNOW

Psychological Appeals

Efforts made by advertisers to associate a product with feeling better about ourselves.

2. Ethics in Advertising

Imagine a product for children, with the ad targeting parents. Such commercials often have images of happy families, and the mother might turn to the camera at the end and justify the purchase of the product with a line like, “They’re worth it!” If advertising frames the purchase of the product as the act of a loving parent rather than an extravagance, they suggest that parents who don’t buy it don’t feel their children are “worth it.” Children may adopt this view. Many ads similarly play not only on associations of the product with success and happiness, but prey on insecurities, making the audience feel bad or insufficient if they do not buy the product. This is how psychological appeals become successful, and when they do work, this often constitutes a victory for the power of psychological persuasion at the expense of ethical truthfulness.



TRY IT

Watch commercial television for an hour. For each commercial you see, ask what is implied by the commercial that has nothing to do with the actual product being sold. Pay attention to the images and to the “story” the commercial tells.

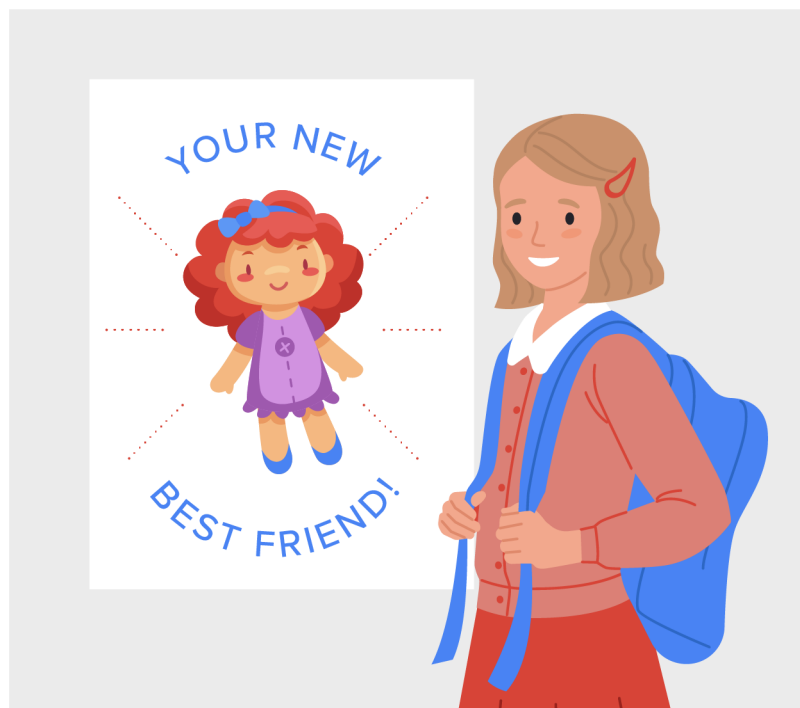
As long as advertisers refrain from breaking the law or engaging in outright lies, are they still acting ethically in undertaking influential advertising campaigns that may drive gullible consumers to purchase products with minimal usefulness? Is this simply the free market in operation? In other words, are manufacturers just supplying a product, promoting it, and then seeing whether customers respond positively to it? Or are savvy marketing campaigns exerting too much influence on consumers who are ill-prepared to resist them? Many people have long asked exactly these questions, and we still have arrived at no clear consensus as to how to answer them. Yet it remains an obligation of each new generation of marketers to reflect on these points and, at the very least, establish their convictions about them.

➔ **EXAMPLE** One testament to the power of advertising is the short-lived fad of the “pet rock,” conceived of in 1975 by Gary Dahl as “the perfect pet.” The pet rock was simply a box with a rock in it and a humorous manual on how to care for it. The rocks retailed at four dollars (about \$22 in 2023) and cost practically nothing, so Dahl enjoyed a large profit. Notably, Dahl was an advertising executive and used his skills to convince people to pay for a rock they could pick up for free on a walk outside!

The ethical questions are not only for the advertisers, but the consumers. Do people have an ethical obligation to minimize the influence advertising has on their decisions? Should they minimize the amount they are exposed to the messages? For example, does a perceived “deal” on an unhealthy food option justify the purchase? When an unwise purchase is made appealing, where does the consumer’s responsibility for decision making lie? Furthermore, if the purchase is spurred by children who are responding to advertising specifically directed at them, is consumer responsibility diminished?

These questions have no consensus answers, but they underlie any discussion of the point at which sophisticated advertising runs headlong into people’s obligation to take responsibility for the wisdom of their purchases.

3. Advertising and Children



Children are more susceptible than adults to empty promises made or implied by advertisements.

Most people would agree that children are more susceptible to the ads commercial television rains over them regularly, or the ads that pop up when they play games and watch videos online. Generally, young children have not developed sufficient judgment to know what advertised products are good for them and which ones have little or no benefit or perhaps can even harm. Research has even shown that very young children have difficulty separating what is real on television from what is not. This is especially so as it pertains to advertising for junk food. Savvy marketers take advantage of the fact that children under 8 years old view advertising in the same manner they do information from trustworthy adults—that is, as very credible—and so marketers hone pitches for junk food directly to these children.

Even if children don't buy the products advertised, the explicit and implicit messages can be damaging. The effects of advertising on the body image of girls, for example, is well documented. Slender women in ads send the message that it is how girls must look to be pretty, resulting in body insecurities that can turn into low self-esteem or eating disorders (Roeder, 2015). Boys and girls alike may feel that they need expensive clothing and shoes to fit in and be popular, and may change their behavior with each other, and views about themselves, because of it.

What restrictions could we reasonably impose on those who gear their ads toward children and teens? We could argue that they should take special care that ads targeting children make absolutely no exaggerated claims, because children are less capable of seeing through the usual puffery that most of us ignore. Children's brains are still growing and transforming, and the messages they take in can influence and impact them. Children are more literal, and once they gain the ability to understand messages directed toward them, especially when voiced by adult authority figures, they typically accept these as truthful statements.



THINK ABOUT IT

A company tasked with selling burgers and fries may draw the line at suggesting the food is healthy, but what about pushing the idea that fast food is “fun”? That hamburgers grow in hamburger patches and love to be eaten? What are their ethical obligations to the client, and to the company they work for?

We have no easy answers to these questions, though they have taken on special urgency as technology has expanded the range of advertising even to our smartphones, and children grow up using them, less supervised than they used to be and sometimes able to even spend money with a click or two.

4. Social Media

Relevant to any discussion of the influence and ethics of advertising is the dominance of social media, which is where many people now encounter the most ads. Kelly Jensen, a digital-marketing consultant, observed that we inhabit a “Digital Era” in which “the internet is arguably the single most influential factor of our culture—transforming the way we view communication, relationships, and even ourselves.” Social media platforms have become a must for companies to create brand awareness, drive revenue, engage current customers, and attract new ones. These are bold claims—as are the claims of some advertising—but Jensen argues convincingly that social media platforms reach many consumers, especially younger ones, who simply cannot be captured by conventional advertising campaigns. For those who derive most of the significant information that shapes their lives through digital media, social media-based appeals most influence their purchasing decisions.

IN CONTEXT

One of the most successful uses of social media in advertising was the Dove #RealBeauty campaign

—actually a set of campaigns that have delivered positive messages to girls for almost 20 years. These campaigns included far more women of color, women with different body shapes, and women with disabilities, than any previous ad campaign, and they were especially a stark contrast to most ads in the beauty industry. The public reception was overwhelmingly positive and led to many people sharing the ads with their own networks (Global Brands, n.d.). Sales of the product surged, based on consumers' positive impression of the company. Indeed, the campaign was so effective that company leaders say it changed the company, making leaders want to do more to live up to the positive image of the company the ads created. However, Dove received public rebuke in 2017 when their Facebook page included a 3-second video many perceived as racist. While they quickly removed the ad and apologized, the public criticism continued, including from prominent celebrities (The Guardian, 2017). Dove learned that even with a decade of goodwill, one poorly conceived post can do a lot of damage to the brand.

This upending of conventional modes of advertising has begun to change the content of ads dramatically. It certainly presents a new stage on which people as young as their teens increasingly rely for help in choosing what to buy. Many marketers have come to appreciate that if they are not spreading the word about their products and services via an electronic source, younger audiences will ignore it. But this brings its own set of ethical questions and concerns. Social media designers have learned from video games, film, and television, and even gambling, and know how to offer dopamine hits from rewards such as likes, reshares, and replies, as well as the anxiety over missing out. They play to these attributes to sell their products. They combine persuasion with entertainment, social interaction and popularity with consumption, and conformity and brand affiliation with popularity, prestige, and success.

Undeniably, a digital environment for advertising, selling, and delivering products and services functions as a two-edged sword for business. It provides lightning-quick access to potential customers, but it also opens pathways for sensitive corporate and consumer data to be hacked on an alarming scale. It offers astute companies nearly unlimited capacity to brand themselves positively in the minds of purchasers, but it simultaneously offers a platform for disgruntled stakeholders to assail companies for both legitimate and self-serving reasons. The drama itself is part of the spectacle, and according to the old adage, any publicity is good publicity. Controversy is the lifeblood of the entertainment industry, and social media has a firm presence in entertainment.

➔ **EXAMPLE** In 2017, the official McDonald's Twitter account was hacked and posted critical remarks to then-president Donald Trump. Though only up for 20 minutes, the post quickly gained hundreds of responses, many from angry supporters vowing to never eat there again (Yurieff, 2017).

While modern advertising via social media inherits all of the ethical questions from traditional advertising regarding selling products people don't need and making exaggerated or outright suggestions through psychological appeals, there are thus additional ethical concerns with social media. If a company (and therefore the shareholders) loses money because of a hijacked or misused social media account, who is to blame? How can companies use social media ethically without getting lost in the sea of posts? However, simply abstaining from social media does not seem to be an option anymore.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you learned about **pervasive persuasion**, the constant bombardment with messages to buy things you don't need. Most ads appeal to your emotions instead of your reason. Instead of offering specific information, indirect claims, associations, and relationships are portrayed over and over: buy this product and you'll be more popular, or more respected, or happier. **Ethics in advertising**

is the dilemma of when this behavior crosses the line. For example, should **ads for children** be more regulated since children are too young to critique the messages? This is especially important with **social media**, which is particularly influential with children and young adults, who may assimilate the messages without question.

Source: THIS TUTORIAL HAS BEEN ADAPTED FROM OPENSTAX "BUSINESS ETHICS". ACCESS FOR FREE AT [OPENSTAX.ORG/BOOKS/BUSINESS-ETHICS/PAGES/1-INTRODUCTION](https://openstax.org/books/business-ethics/pages/1-introduction). LICENSE: [CREATIVE COMMONS ATTRIBUTION 4.0 INTERNATIONAL](https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/).

REFERENCES

Galbraith, J.K. (1958). *The Affluent Society*. New York: Houghton Mifflin.

The Guardian (2017, October 8). Dove apologizes for ad showing black woman turning into white one. www.theguardian.com/world/2017/oct/08/dove-apologises-for-ad-showing-black-woman-turning-into-white-one

Global Brands (n.d.). *The Success of Dove's Real Beauty Campaign*. www.globalbrandsmagazine.com/the-success-of-doves-real-beauty-campaign/

Hollis, N. (2011, August 31). Why Good Advertising Works (Even When You Think It Doesn't). *The Atlantic*. www.theatlantic.com/business/archive/2011/08/why-good-advertising-works-even-when-you-think-it-doesnt/244252/

Roeder, A. (2015, March 18). *Advertising's toxic effect on eating and body image* Harvard School of Public Health. www.hsph.harvard.edu/news/features/advertisings-toxic-effect-on-eating-and-body-image/

Yurieff, K.(2017, March 17). *McDonald's: Anti-Trump tweet came from 'compromised' account* CNN. money.cnn.com/2017/03/16/technology/mcdonalds-trump-tweet/



TERMS TO KNOW

Psychological Appeals

Efforts made by advertisers to associate a product with feeling better about ourselves.